Domenico Romoli — Dottrina singolare, Book I only (1637)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 17 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the subject reviewers are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

To Domenico Romoli of Florence, cook and steward, who was not a lord writing about banquets from above; he was the man who staged them, and wrote down how it is done so another young man could learn. He published under his kitchen nickname, proud enough to set it on the title page. His birth and death dates are not recorded, and none are asserted here.

The author's own terms

Scalco — the steward, commanding the prince's table, its service, and the officers below him; *scalco secreto*, his confidential steward. Below him: *spenditore*, buyer of provisions; *cuoco secreto*, private cook; *credenziere*, keeper of the sideboard and pantry; *bottigliere*, keeper of bottles and wine; *dispensiere*, keeper of the storeroom; *panattiere*, bread-keeper; *soprastante del piatto*, overseer of serving; *coppiere*, cupbearer; *trinciante*, carver. A *convito* is a banquet; *imbandire*, to set out the table; the *credenze* are the ceremonial tastings before dishes reach the lord, never to be skipped.

The story

The story that can honestly be told is the work's story: no birth or death date, place of death, employer, or career episode was found in any source consulted, and none is invented here. The ILAB gastronomy catalogue says he was born in Florence and was not only a cook, but also a *scalco*, a steward who directed great households' tables. He flourished by 1560, the year his book first appeared. The book is addressed to a younger man who had begged to be taught the office.

The work and what survives

The first edition, according to the Leland Little auction record, was Venice: Michele Tramezzino, 1560, as *La singolare dottrina*, in (16), 376 leaves. The ILAB catalogue summarises its thirteen books as the *scalco* and his officers, then dishes for each season and month, and finally diet and health advice. Katherine Golden Bitting judged it "one of the most famous Italian 16th-century cookery books," *Gastronomic Bibliography*, p. 403 — the folder's citation, corroborated exactly, same words and page, by the auction record.

What this project holds is partial: Book I (chapters I–XV) only, translated from the 1637 Combi printing, not the 1560 first edition. Those chapters, "Dello ammaestramento del famoso scalco," contain no recipes, quantities, doses, or remedies; they give the office, its officers, the ordinary table, the wedding feast, and the great banquets. Books II–XIII — the seasons, menus, and cookery — are not Englished here.

The nickname stands unsettled. The 1560 title page, as the folder transcribes it, names him "soprannominato Panunto"; the 1637 title reads "Panonto," and the ILAB catalogue notes a first-edition issue with "Panonto" instead of "Panunto." The catalogue glosses it "Fried Bread"; the folder, "oiled bread," bread rubbed with fat. Both spellings and both glosses stand, each tied to its edition and source, and neither side is settled.

Its English fortunes

No complete, free English rendering of Romoli's Book I (the "Ufficio dello scalco," chapters I–XV) was found after research.

That finding stands at the folder's own strength: its search of 11 October 2026,

re-run in substance on 16 October 2026, found Italian reprints and no English translation of Book I or of the whole work. Its bound belongs in this same section: a paywalled rendering would not have surfaced in these searches, and no WorldCat or union-catalogue sweep was run. What exists in English, per the folder's closing note, is scattered reenactor redactions of individual recipes from the later cookery books.

What completing it would take

The Book I rendering still lacks the final checks and independent Italian review its draft banner says have not yet happened. The repair log its rendering note refers to is not in the folder; producing it, so its passages can be listed and checked, or striking the reference, is open work, and the log is not cited here. If first-edition authority is wanted, the 1637 Combi text must be collated against the 1560 Tramezzino text; no collation has been made, and this holding's authority is the 1637 printing alone. Books II–XIII remain untranslated; completing Romoli whole is a separate, larger commission. On re-shelving, its directory is to be renamed for the 1637 source, since its present name wrongly suggests 1560.

Sources

- Project folder: `~/workspace/rare-and-obscure-books/books/romoli-scalco-1560/romoli-scalco-1560.txt` — Book I (chapters I–XV) only, from the 1637 Combi printing, not the 1560 first edition
- PIN: `~/workspace/packages/boneyard-extension/research/PIN-romoli.md`
- ILAB gastronomy catalogue: https://ilab.org/assets/catalogues/catalogs_files_3057_list_20gastronomy.pdf
- Leland Little auction record, 1560 edition: https://www.lelandlittle.com/items/517497/original-edition-of-domenico-romoli-s-famous-treatise-on-the-culinary-arts?departmentId=18
- Bitting, *Gastronomic Bibliography*, p. 403, as cited in the folder and corroborated by the auction record